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Examiners' Report
June 2025

Int GCSE English Language 4EA1 02R

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June 2025

Publications Code 4EA1_02R_2506_ER

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Introduction

This report will provide exemplification of candidates' work, together with tips and comments, for Paper 2R of the International GCSE Specification A in English Language. This was the summer series of the 'A' specification in International GCSE English Language 9-1.

The specification consists of three components:

Component 1: Non-fiction and Transactional Writing - 60% (examination)

Component 2: Poetry and Prose Texts and Imaginative Writing - 40% (this examination) OR Unit 3: Poetry and Prose Texts and Imaginative Writing - 40% (non-examination assessment).

Candidates may also be entered for the optional Spoken Language Endorsement (non-examination assessment).

Component 2 for Poetry and Prose Texts and Imaginative Writing is assessed through an examination lasting one hour and thirty minutes. The total number of marks available is 60. The reading and writing sections on this paper are loosely linked by the theme of the text from the Anthology which appears on the examination paper.

This focus of this component is:

Section A – Poetry and Prose Texts: study and analyse selections from a range of fictional poetry and prose texts.

Candidates should study the poetry and prose provided in Part 2 of the *Pearson Edexcel International GCSE English Anthology* in preparation for responding to a given prose extract or poem in theexamination.

The specification identifies that candidates: *should be able to read substantial pieces of writing (extended texts) that make significant demands on them in terms of content, structure and the quality of language. Throughout the qualification, candidates should develop the skills of inference and analysis.*

Candidates are advised to allocate 45 minutes to Section A, and there will be one essay question on a poetry or prose text from Part 2 of the *Pearson Edexcel International GCSE English Anthology*, which will be made available in a booklet in the examination if it is a longer extract or will be in the Question Paper in the case of a poem.

Candidates will answer the question in this section and 30 marks are available. There are three bullet points to prompt the response and the third bullet always asks candidates to consider language and structure.

Section B – Imaginative Writing: explore and develop imaginative writing skills.

Candidates are advised to allocate 45 minutes to Section B. There are three writing tasks, to some extent linked by theme to the reading prose extract or poem. Candidates pick one question to respond to and the response is worth 30 marks. The format of the tasks remains the same for

each series – Question 1 follows the format 'Write about a time when you, or someone you know…', Question 2 follows the format 'Write a story with the title…' and Question 3 offers two images as a prompt for a response which is always 'Write a story that begins…' or 'Write a story that ends…'.

The Assessment Objectives for this paper are:

Section A: Reading

AO1:

read and understand a variety of texts, selecting and interpreting information, ideas and perspectives

AO2: understand and analyse how writers use linguistic and structural devices to achieve their effects.

Section B: Writing

AO4: communicate effectively and imaginatively, adapting form, tone and register of writing for specific purposes and audiences

AO5: write clearly, using a range of vocabulary and sentence structures, with appropriate paragraphing and accurate spelling, grammar and punctuation.

It was clear that candidates were all able to respond to the poem from the Anthology in the examination, and that most had studied it before. Some candidates had been taught the context of the poem, the background to the poem and the writer.

Throughout the assessment overall candidates had been prepared well and all had, at different levels, developed the skills required to answer the questions.

It was also clear that candidates used what they had studied in their reading to feed into their imaginative writing, which inspired them.

As the specification identifies, the main aims for our candidates in this paper are:

- read critically and use knowledge gained from wide reading to inform and improve their own writing
- write effectively and coherently using Standard English appropriately
- use grammar correctly, punctuate and spell accurately
- acquire and apply a wide vocabulary alongside knowledge and understanding of grammatical terminology, and linguistic conventions for reading, writing and spoken language.

Candidates had, pleasingly, been given the opportunity to practise their writing techniques and planning and proofreading skills.

As Principal Examiner for this paper it was a privilege to read such accomplished work and to see the engagement, interest and significant hard work in the responses candidates had completed.

The responses of candidates had some positive features. Examiners were impressed by:

- evidence that many candidates had understood and engaged with the content of and ideas in the poem
- the successful, integrated use of the bullet points within the question in order to scaffold responses
- coverage of the assessment objectives required for this paper
- the range of ideas and creativity for AO4
- the attempt to vary vocabulary and punctuation for AO5
- writing that showed at least appropriate tone, style and register for audience and purpose.

Less successful responses:

- demonstrated a lack of knowledge of the poem and/or lack of awareness of the ideas in the poem specifically relevant to the question
- failed to reference the question, with candidates simply writing something about the poem or writer very broadly
- rigidly followed the bullet points in the question so that language and structure points were almost an 'add-on' at the end – there are 18 marks available for this Assessment Objective
- had an insecure grasp of language and structure with a lack of understanding of how these were used, feature-spotting or confusion of terms
- had limited comment on language and structure and relied heavily on description of the poem or paraphrasing of it for Question 1
- failed to support points using appropriate textual evidence, used over-long quotations or tried to use the same quotations to support both AO1 and AO2. This is only acceptable where the points made are different
- lacked organisation in their writing
- lacked accurate spelling and secure control of punctuation and grammar in imaginative writing.

It was clear that candidates had been able to find at least some information about how the writer presents events. Some candidates could, at the very least, comment on language and structural features. Imaginative writing was often interesting, engaging and enthusiastic and had a clear sense of purpose and audience in the voice and ideas used.

Question 1

How does the writer present events in *The Bright Lights of Sarajevo*?

This question assesses AO1 and AO2.

AO1: Read and understand a variety of texts, selecting and interpreting information, ideas and perspectives.

The level of understanding of the text from the Anthology is assessed in the first bullet point in the AO1 mark scheme, and the selection and interpretation of information, ideas and perspectives in the text in the second bullet point. Overall, candidates clearly engaged with the overall ideas in the poem. The bullet points in the question were followed by the vast majority of candidates and helped them to demonstrate selection and understanding of, for example, the contrast between the hardship of the day and the more hopeful, human moments that occur at night.

Responses that were less successful tended to comment very broadly on what was being said in the poem. They were able to show some understanding of the poem, but the understanding and focus was uneven. In these less successful responses, there was limited selection and interpretation of information and ideas. These responses sometimes lacked a secure understanding of the poem's context or misinterpreted key ideas, often relying on retelling the poem in order, with limited selection of relevant detail. In some cases, candidates offered personal opinions on war or relationships without anchoring their ideas in the text.

The responses at the mid-level were at least able to identify some of the key events happening by day and by night and the contrast between them, although there was sometimes an imbalance where the focus was on identifying basic/valid ideas and information from the poem that had some interesting ideas rather than being appropriate, apt or persuasive for the higher levels in the AO1 mark scheme. These responses often demonstrated sound understanding of the poem's meaning but were more descriptive than analytical. These responses tended to summarise events rather than explore the writer's craft in detail. Common references included the bread queues, snipers, and the use of darkness to hide identity.

The most successful responses were able to select the relevant ideas from the poem relating to events in a detailed but succinct manner. These responses tended to cover the full poem and offered detailed points, for example those that paid close attention to the detail and showed a secure grasp of both literal and implied meaning, particularly in relation to the resilience of young people in times of war. Some responses at higher levels picked out sophisticated ideas around the way the writer used 'bread' to highlight cultural difference and also to highlight the horrors of war. One examiner noted 'I saw a lot of responses where candidates focused on the contrasts in the poem, and these were well developed and sustained, their ideas fully supported by reference to the text.'

Some typical ideas included the concepts around light and dark reflecting day and night, the boy and girl and how love overcame war. Examiners noted candidates related to the poem on a personal level and firmly understood the atrocities of war but the innocence of love. They felt candidates seemed to grasp that concept and some were able to discuss it confidently.

AO2: Understand and analyse how writers use linguistic and structural devices to achieve their effects.

There are 18 marks available for this Assessment Objective and, in some cases, there was too much focus on AO1, with a few comments on language and structure added on at the end. The quotations used to support these points must also stand independently of those used to illustrate AO1 points, as they cannot be credited twice for the same point.

There needs to be more than just identification (Level 1). There should be at least some understanding of the language and structure used in the text, and the level of skill is a good discriminator. *Explain* is a mid-level skill, *comment* a lower-level skill and *explore/analyse* higher-level skills, which gives candidates opportunities to achieve across the range.

The less successful responses often made reference to language and structure as a brief add-on at the end of the answer. Candidates here often identified and named devices, but did not demonstrate the skill or understanding to discuss their use, and did not link these to the question. At this level, responses were characterised by writing without any explanations – candidates here were good at finding both language and structure features, but not as confident at explaining them. The responses were much more at a descriptive level, with limited and underdeveloped evidence. Comments on language at lower levels were often generalised, with vague assertions such as 'this makes the reader feel emotional.'

Mid-level responses were at least commenting on both language and structure. At this level candidates were commenting on and explaining language and structure, with appropriate and relevant references. These responses were able to pick out features in the poem, but often there was little developed explanation of the effect of these features. The majority of fairly successful responses were able to comment clearly on, for example, simile, metaphor, emotive language, contrast, vivid imagery and repetition. Some explanations at this level were non-specific and repeated the question: 'The writer uses language and structure to engage the reader.'

The most successful responses were making points about both language and structure consistently, confidently and succinctly. These responses explored and analysed language and structure, with detailed and discriminating references. At the higher levels candidates were able to analyse the writer's choices with precision, showing an appreciation of tone, structure, and figurative language. The juxtaposition between the 'blood-dunked crusts of shredded bread' and the flirtatious moments between young people was explored with thoughtful insight. These candidates embedded short, relevant quotations and moved beyond identifying devices to commenting on their effect. Imagery such as the 'tender radar' and the shell holes reflecting the Pleiades was often interpreted symbolically and connected to wider ideas about beauty, loss, and hope.

Examiners' comments included:

- Candidates often wrote about the pass/gas rhyming and the boy/girl figure to demonstrate structure and contrast.
- Candidates were able to pick out the pram/gram and stroller stride language choices but they discussed different meanings which was interesting to see the variety of responses.

- Some discussed innocence while others focused on the pace and alliteration
- Many candidates were able to comment on the effect of imagery in the poem, where others easily identified devices and confidently spoke about the metaphors and military lexical choices.

Structural points included the change from day to night, rhyme, juxtaposition and short sentences. Many responses showed confidence in analysing the poet's intentions and were detached and critical in regard to their style of writing, discussing, for example, how enjambment added pace and then related this to the struggles of the people as they were shelled. Overall, the most successful responses took a detached viewpoint and were able to discuss at length how Harrison used both language and structure to highlight the struggles of the people, and then focused on the hope of the young couple and the 'candle light' which reflected this.

leaving the Sarajevo star-filled evening sky
ideally bright and clear for bomber's eye,
in those two rain-full shell-holes the boy sees
fragments of the splintered Pleiades,
sprinkled on those death-deep, death-dark wells
splashed on the pavement by Serb mortar shells.

The dark boy shape leads dark girl shape away
to share one coffee in a candlelit café
until the curfew, and he holds her hand
behind AID flour sacks refilled with sand.

Tony Harrison

1 How does the writer present events in *The Bright Lights of Sarajevo*?

In your answer, you should write about:

- the events that happen by day
- events that happen at night
- the use of language and structure.

You should support your answer with close reference to the poem, including **brief** quotations.

(30)

~~For~~

At the first paragraph, Tony use ~~rhythm~~ ryme for a lot to tell how time ~~are~~ are passing and how things are going.
He use the ryme for ~~each~~ two lines each.
At first he use "pass" and "gas" and at the second time he use "prams" and "grams". Using ryme will make easier to know the happing of story.

At the second paragraph, Tony use ~~lots of~~ ~~to~~ use "black" or "dark" to tell this events is happen at day. ~~or~~ Also these word make negative ~~and~~ ~~image~~ and ~~of~~ ~~quite~~ quiet situation

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Examiner Comments

AO1 (1 mark): This is a limited response. There is very little about the poem given other than how time is passing and how things are going. There are no references that link to those AO1 points. Only 1 mark can be awarded for AO1.

AO2 (3 marks): There are a couple more points offered on language and structure. There is some identification of features, rhyme for example and negative images, but this is limited identification. There is selection of references to support the features but it is very limited and there is not really anything more than simple comment on how they are used, for example, 'easier to know the happening of story'. A mark of 3 for AO2 can be awarded at the top of Level 1.

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In the poem 'Bright light of sarajevo, events that happen over day is very diskerent with the event that happens in night time.

Bright, Light are usually for describing a good peace time in a day, but in this poem it is totally the opesite. During day time, people 'often dodging ~~the~~ snipers' on the street, 'empty canisters of gas' 'stair with water' all shows ~~the~~ what war brings to Sarajevo. 'People walking streets serb shells destroyed' solders 'distinguish' who ever calls bread 'hileb or Heb or Kruh'.

During night time in sarajevo, the god of death don't usually come in this time, the sarajevo night time brings peace

to the livings, they live under the darkness but they also enjoy the darkness. The night brings a short break for war. And so night time is a great time for people to come out from hide and seek, from the poem 'The young go walking' "Black shapes are impossible to mark them as 'muslim', they walk together to a place where ~~was~~ no one would found, And now 'even the smallest clouds have cleared away, leaving the sarajevo star-filled evening sky,' 'when a girl's dark shape is fancied by a boy's. Then the tender radar of the tone of voice shows by it's signals she approves his choice.'

for the poem, it was never the sunshine which brigtens up the sarajevo, & it was the love of two youngth who brights of each others Sarajevo.

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Examiner Comments

AO1 (5 marks): For AO1 we can award a mark in the middle of Level 2, a mark of 5. There is some valid selection of ideas - the events are very different from day to night, what war brings to Sarajevo, the idea about death, people living in darkness and the love story between the young people. There is some valid selection but the references are imbalanced. While some are valid, the references on the second page are quite lengthy.

AO2 (2 marks): For AO2, there is no identification of language and structure at all. We can credit some implied reference to language and structure where the candidate, for example, says 'all shows what war brings' and the contrast between night and day. For that reason, we can award a mark of 2 in Level 1 for that implied understanding. We cannot credit references twice for AO1 and AO2, unless they are used to support different points.

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(30)

Harrison present ~~war~~ Sarajevo 's daily events as harsh and dangerous. Due to war, people in ~~Sra~~ Sarajevo are all struggle for life. Harrison describes ~~how~~ how people "queuing for the precious meagre grams of bread..." to show their lack of resources. The use of "grams" to describe "bread" shows the scarcity of basic necessaties in Sarajevo, people could only measure food in "grams". This reveal how ~~pressure~~ precious resources are and mirroring the harsh living condition of people in Sarajevo. Harrison further suggests the difficulties in life by suggesting people need to "struggling up sometimes eleven flights of stair with water". The ~~water~~ use of labour instead of machine reflect the lack of infrastructure in Sarajevo, people need to do everything by themselves. The number "eleven" highlight

the struggle of living, create a sense of tire, which makes reader feel sympathy for people in Sarajevo since they need to work so hard to live and the living condition is harsh. Moreover, people's daily life is also dangerous. Harrisons writes there is "often dodging snipers on the way" which means people couldn't even move freely on the street, they always need to worry about coming dangerous and could loss their lives at at any time. This brutal image will shocke the readers and make them feel pity for those people.

~~The~~ The events at night in sarajevo becomes more friendly and ~~pere~~ peaceful. When night comes, ~~there is~~ people cannot see eachother clearly and their won't be discrimination or racism. By using the listing of "Muslim, Serb, or Croat" Harrison suggests the complex of believes and society ~~and~~. But as night comes, there will be

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Examiner Comments

AO1 (9 marks): This response demonstrates sound understanding of the poem. Although the idea of the harsh and dangerous ideas in the poem is repeated, the selection is appropriate and relevant. For example, the candidate covers the struggle of the people, the lack of resources and the labour-intensive experiences. We have the idea of the people being friendly and peaceful at night and there being no racism or discrimination at night and we can see that the references are appropriate and relevant to those points. The response therefore achieves the top of Level 3 in AO1.

AO2 (6 marks): The response is unfinished but there are some features identified. For example, there are some word level features identified – 'grams' to describe bread, the number 11, brutal imagery and also listing. There is only some identification. The textual references are accurate and there is a little bit of developing comment linked to those points. For example, Harrison suggests the 'complex of believes and society'. The top of Level 2 is achieved, a mark of 6.

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Tony Harrison presented the events that happened by day, showing people's life during the war in Sarajevo. Harrison used many verb such as "dodging" "struggling" and the repetition of ~~"queuing"~~ "quering" to described people's daily life. Both "dodging" and "struggling" held a negative and pathetic tone, indicating that people were like homeless rats, hiding themselves to avoid the bomb that could easily take away their lives. The word "struggling" indicated people in Sarajevo were painful, and barely alive. The word "quering" showed people's passive position, that they could only wait ~~for~~ ~~to~~ for food. Food means survival,

~~which reveals~~ Thus, people queuing ~~for~~ for food reveals they were queuing to be saved. Their lives were depended on others instead of ~~them~~ themselves.

Tom Harrison presented the events that happened at night, showing people's secret behaviours and the danger at night. Harrison ~~used triplet to~~ wrote that at night it was impossible to defined: "Muslim, Serb or Croat". This use of ~~triplets~~ listing revealed the cultural ~~div~~ diversity in Sarajevo. This listing gave ~~a sense of unstop~~ an unstoppable feeling, implied that the darkness acted as a ~~protection~~ barrier to protect people when they walked on the streets. The different ~~religious~~ group indicated that ~~everyone~~ ethnicities indicated that ~~every kin~~ everyone was equally small ~~to~~ and weak ~~facing~~ while facing war. The writer also wrote that at night there were "no torches guide them but they don't collide" The internal rhyme of "guide" and "collide" juxposed with each other, "guide" represented peace and ~~rational~~ gave a rational imagery. While "collide" ~~represented~~ is representing chaos and to break the rules. This juxposition implied the uncertainty during war time in Sarajevo. And people can

walked with no light guided them indicated two truths. First one is that there were very small amount of people in the street, ~~which may~~ due to their fear towards darkness and war. People might be afraid a single bomb fell on the place they couldn't see, which may easily take away their lives. Another ~~possibilities~~ possibility was that people ~~#~~ were already get used to the darkness like abyss. They were afraid to "collide which may ~~#~~ get them into trouble, into an unsafe situation. So people trained themselves to be silent and organised in their "free" time.

Tom Harrison also prasented people's Love in the Sarajevo. ~~The~~ From Line 21 to 24, and from Line 43 to 46. These are the two shortest stanzas, written about the love between two young ~~pe~~ girl and boy. The ~~#~~ length of these two stanza indicated the fragility of love during war. Although they loved each other, they ~~could easily~~ couldn't have anything more at the ~~#~~ time. The writer wrote the "tender radar of the tone of voice / shows by its signals she approves his choice." The use of ~~#~~ semantic field of war "tender radar" "signals" fit the ways people used to detected and communicated during wartime.

Harrison used ~~this~~ these words to described how two young people ~~fell in love during the war~~ were flirting. This also indicates how ~~these couples~~ they used ~~love~~ love as their weapons to fight the harsh reality. ~~Furthermore, we could notice that~~ However, in the fourth stanza the writer wrote that the couple were decided to "leaving the Sarajaro star-filled evening sky / ideally bright and clear for bomber's eyes." This use of irony indicated the ~~cruelty~~ cruelty of war, people couldn't enjoy the peaceful art of nature at the moment, since they have to pay attention to avoid the bomb attack, ~~Further indi~~ this "star-filled" evening sky showed the bright future of people in Sarajaro, while the next line dragged the audience out of the peaceful utopia ~~the writer created~~ that lasted ~~a~~ just a short time, ~~reintroduced the cruelty of war~~ reintroduced the cruelty of war. Furthermore, the couples ~~were~~ was nameless in the poem, which ~~meant that they~~ represented million of people who used love to ~~strengthen~~ ~~strongth~~ strethened themselves and overcame the obstacles ~~to~~ together during wartime. ~~But~~ However, lot of them may still be defeated by the relentless war.

In conclusion, Tom Harrison presented people's life in Sarajevo in both day and night. He ~~hight~~ highlighted people's difficulties and harshness during the war. Also criticizing the cruelty of war and praising the love between people, that they used as their weapons to fight the ~~en~~ cruel reality.

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Examiner Comments

AO1 (10 marks): This response achieves all of the bullet points of Level 3 for AO1 and there is some sustained reference to the poem. The selection and interpretation is appropriate and supports the points being made. There is a touch of the evidence being quite detailed that we have difficulties, harshness, the secrets that happen at night time, ideas of ethnicity and equality, fear, darkness, hope and love. For that reason, we can see that whilst we could have a little bit more detail in order to reach the top end of Level 4, we can just edge the response into that level with a mark of 10 for AO1.

AO2 (12 marks): For AO2 there are a number of features explained. There is some word-level explanation, for example the word 'struggling' indicated people were in pain. The idea of the negative tone being created is explained. The response moves into more exploration as it goes on. For example, listing revealing cultural diversity, the internal rhyme juxtaposing ideas and implying uncertainty. This exploration is also seen in stanza length. There is some detail in the reference to language and structure and some quite thorough selection and for that reason a mark just at the lower end of Level 4 is awarded.

leaving the Sarajevo star-filled evening sky
ideally bright and clear for bomber's eye, juxtaposition
in those two rain-full shell-holes the boy sees
fragments of the splintered Pleiades, symbolism
sprinkled on those death-deep, death-dark wells repetition
splashed on the pavement by Serb mortar shells.

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(30)

The Bright Lights of Sarajevo explores the resilience and love in people during wartime in Sarajevo.

Firstly, the writer presents the events as disastrous effects of war. This can be seen in the listing of dynamic verbs "queuing", "dodging" and "struggling". During the time, Serbs were fighting in Sarajevo, around 1992. People desparately needed neccessities like water, food, and electricity, but these were all kept by the serbs. During daylight, everyone is exposed to "snipers", they would need to "struggle" and "dodge" to avoid being seen by their enemies. These verbs highlights the fear and nervousness in people during day, since they have no where to hide or survive. they are hiding from threats, and queuing for necessities Also, the phrase "streets Serb shells destroyed". This sibilance mimics the hissing sound of a snake,

signifying threats and dangers. This elongates the pain in people caused by the bombardments from the Serbs. The readers can understand how the Serbs have brought drastic catastrophe to the place, and how the people are experiencing shortage and survival difficulties. Furthermae, the euphemism of "shredded bread" represents the dead bodies in the light killed by ruthless weapons. This violent imagery presented in the lines underscores the cruelty and helplessness of people. The readers may evoke sympathy towards their desperation, and ~~feel~~ evoke hatred towards the behavior of attacking of the Serbs.

In addition, the writer presents the events in darkness, but the people with resilience and romance. This can be seen in the phrase, "you'd". This direct address offers the readers' identity as an outsider of war, a person who is experiencing luxurious life rather than like the characters in the poem, in war. This shows how the reality at night is actually different from the expectations of the reader. The phrase "stroller's stride" demonstrates alliteration. This creates contrast with readers' expectations, since the readers expect people in Sarajevo to hide and be afraid of being shot, so they should be running. However, the romantic imagery ~~of~~ created by the diction "flirtatious", further shows how the people are with hope and love. They are "flirting" with each other even enjoying the time during the night. Usually, in daylights, people can feel warmth and safety, however, in this poem,

the events that happen under daylight are rather violent and ruthless compared to the loving and close relationship built at night. The juxtaposition between romantic imagery like "holds her hand", and militaristic imagery like "massacre" and "shell-holes" illustrates how people are still with hope and the firm heart of surviving in this war. The contrast between "dark" and "bright" presents the unusual characteristics of the events. ~~Also, the phrase "splintered However,~~ The phrase "splintered Pleiades" symbolizes the hope in people, however, the adjective "splintered" reveals the cruel reality that deaths are still happening, the harshness and events like "empty canisters" can't actually be changed. The title "Bright Lights of Sarajevo" represents the hope in people, but this "splintered" star shows the inevitable destiny of deaths in the war. The readers can observe the resilience and romance in the characters, and respect towards their spirit, but at the same time, feel sorry for their situation.

Furthermore, the writer presents the events as being distorting the natural order. This can be seen in the phrase "wheel home in prams". Usually, prams are used to carry babies, filled with love and care, but in this line, the "prams" are used to carry "canisters of gas". This irony of how even the most innocent object can become threatening during war greatly shocks the readers. The readers may feel surprised for the distortion of orders. The anonymity of

using "girl" and "boy" without an actual name suggests that everyone in the place were experiencing such agony. This can evoke great pity from readers towards the scenary. Also, in the phrase "death-deep, death-dark wells". This repetition used further supports this point. "Wells" are often used to provide water that signifies life, but with the adjective of "death", this connotates suffer and pain. This inversion in the function of wells further emphasizes the enormous power wars possess. The verb following this phrase "splashed" further mimics the image of blood splashing onto the floor, painting the scenary with amplified fear. The readers can understand and know how destructive this war is to the people in Sarajevo, and feel sorry for them.

Also, the writer presents the ethical conflicts as the cause of the war. This can be seen in the phrase "Muslim, Serb or Croat". This listing of ethinity shows how darkness has covered all differences in people, they are protected from outside threats, and this also tells the reader that the war is caused by different ethics yet they did nothing wrong. In addition, the consistent end-stop lines in the first few stanzas like "each day.", "destroyed" shows and mimics the sharp harms and injuries in the people during war. In contrast, the enjambment in later stanzas like "taken her hand" and "certainly progressed" speeds up the pace. This shows how the sufferings

and conflicts are elongated whereas the humanity and love are presented as brief moments, as short and precious in such period. However, the rhyming scheme of AA BB CCDD EEF in the first stanza presents regular beats that may suggest the monotony of each day, of people facing the same struggles and fear each day. The readers can see from such structure that the destiny and event of deaths, bombardments, and facing "mortars" can't be changed unless the war ends. The events presented in both day and light reveals the cruelty due to conflicts, yet also the warmth in people. The readers can understand the disparity that caused war from nouns like "hjleb", "hleb" and "knuh", and feel miserable for the people.

Lastly, the writer presents the purity of love in people during the war. The word "fancied" demonstrates cartoonish language that conveys naivety, this illustrates how boys and girls are interacting with each other during the night with the thought of seeking accompanionship. The caesura of "curfew, and he holds her hand" further creates a pause for their love, that mimics a pause for them to actually look at each other. However, the short length of the last stanza shows how short their relationship is. The only moment that they can clearly see each other flies away fast, and they would need to hide from "snipers" once

again. The readers can feel sorry and upset for their short and brief moment.

ResultsPlus
Examiner Comments

AO1 (12 marks): The response achieves Level 4 fully for AO1. This response offers sustained coverage across the poem, with very detailed selection of ideas and information. There are points made on every page: resilience, disastrous effects of war, the need for necessities, the threats of war, the resilience and romance shown at night, reality versus the appearance and expectations of the reader, ideas of love and the contrast with the violent and ruthless events of the daytime. The events distorting the natural order is an interesting idea, as is the ethnic conflict that seems to be the cause of the war. The detail goes all the way through the response and a mark of 12 is deserved for AO1.

AO2 (16 marks): For AO2 all of Level 4 is met and there is evidence of Level 5. If we think that all of one level is met, we should consider the next level. There is a bit of a mix throughout the response, there are some language and structure points that are explained, some that are explored (for example, violent imagery is one that is explored), but there are also some areas of analysis of language. For example, the juxtaposition between romantic and militaristic language and the idea of the rhyme presenting regular beats that suggest monotony. The point on page five about the length of the last set stanza and how short their relationship is definitely an example of quite detailed analysis, maybe not perceptive analysis, but definitely detailed analysis. Since there is a mixture within the response of some explanation, some exploration, but also some features of Level 5, we can award a mark at the lower end of Level 5, a mark of 16.

Question 2

General Comments on Section B: Writing

Examiners felt that the writing questions prompted some responses where 'some were very beautifully written.' It is worth noting that examiners always appreciate the writing responses, with one saying, 'responses were on the whole enjoyable to read'.

At the less successful end of the mark scheme candidates tended to offer a basic response. They always had straightforward use of tone, style and register, with audience and purpose not always clear. At this level candidates tended to express but not always connect ideas and information, with limited use of structural and grammatical features and paragraphing. Pleasingly, there were few responses that only achieved Level 1 and where they did this was mostly because these candidates hardly wrote anything, offering a basic response, or the sentences did not make sense at all.

In the mid-level of the mark scheme, candidates tended to at least have straightforward and at best appropriate use of tone, style and register, selecting material and stylistic or rhetorical devices to suit audience and purpose. At this level candidates tended to connect, but not always develop, ideas and information, with some structural and grammatical features and paragraphing.

There was a tendency in the majority of responses marked at this mid-level to set out a stronger description in the start and then focus more on plot towards the end where planning had let the candidates down. In some cases, the writing lacked development to move higher into the mark scheme for AO4. At this level the use of vocabulary and syntax tended to be appropriate but repetitive and at times limited to vague simile or metaphor, use of short sentences, questions and exclamations for effect. The level of AO6 at this level was appropriate but overall formulaic, where it appeared that candidates had been advised to include plenty of adjectives, adverbs or similes in their writing without considering their purpose.

In the most successful responses, candidates tended to have subtle use of tone, style and register, managing ideas and stylistic or rhetorical devices to suit audience and purpose. In these responses candidates tended to manage, but not always manipulate, ideas and information, with a range of structural and grammatical features and paragraphing. The successful responses had some creative ideas and conscious, successful crafting, with some selective vocabulary used for specific effect rather than just to demonstrate knowledge of particular multi-syllabic words.

The Assessment Objectives for these tasks effectively discriminated the quality of responses. Advice to centres would be to encourage candidates to avoid thinking they need to write a whole novel or even short extract in the time available – they need to have a clear organisation and direction in mind, and to perhaps not 'over-season' the pieces with vocabulary and syntax.

The main areas that discriminated these responses were the same as in previous series:

- whether candidates could meet both parts of the first part of bullet one in the mark scheme for AO5 – for example they often expressed ideas to achieve in Level 2, but these ideas lacked the order for the second part of that bullet point. In Level 3, they may have connected ideas but not developed them.

- the success of tone, style and register in AO4.
- the spelling of basic vocabulary in AO5.
- the accuracy of punctuation and use of varied punctuation in AO5.
- the use of a range of sentence structures for AO5.

Varying sentence structure and punctuation were areas centres had focused on: varying the way sentences begin; more use of subordinate clauses to begin complex sentences; effective use of one-word sentences and one-sentence paragraphs to demonstrate conscious crafting. Some candidates attempted to use ambitious vocabulary while some seemed to steer away from ambitious vocabulary in order to maintain accuracy.

A key message to centres is to focus on crafting and organisation whatever the nature of the task. The less successful responses were formulaic, showing a lack of organisation and often demonstrating a lack of planning and direction. Advice to candidates is to be ambitious in the structure, vocabulary and range of ideas and try to be creative and original. There was some excellent description and evidence of crafting at all levels.

In terms of register it was clear that the majority of the candidates knew how to write an imaginative piece, however there were a few that produced responses more like an essay or that did not relate to the question being answered (as this is the purpose of the piece and the audience for the piece, this is essential – responses that are pre-prepared to try and fit the question are rarely successful). As with Summer 2024, a key issue was the achievement of the purpose of the writing, especially when candidates had created what appeared pre-prepared responses which just had a statement bolted on at the end to link it to the title. As one examiner noted, 'This resulted in a cursory reference to the prompt, making the ending feel unnatural.'

Examiners noted that lack of control could let candidates down and that control of language was also a problem at times.

Some comments from examiners include:

- 'Some excellent pieces and some very brief responses.'
- 'The vocabulary was quite rich in some pieces, and I found spelling to be significantly better across all responses.'
- 'Punctuation and sentence structures were also generally accurate but quite standard without too many variations.'
- 'Paragraphing was not always successful across responses and dialogue was used sparingly.'

Question 2: Write about a time when you, or someone you know, went to see friends or family.

This question was the second most popular this summer. Examiners noted that 'This question prompted a wide range of personal and imagined responses.' Many candidates opted to write in the first person, and this often led to useful coherence and emotional connection with the reader. Stories describing long -distance reunions, or traditional family gatherings were popular and effective when structured with a clear sense of progression.

The least successful responses tended to lose focus or lacked sufficient detail. Paragraphing was inconsistent, and technical accuracy often undermined clarity. In particular, errors in tense, sentence punctuation, and dialogue formatting were frequent in these responses. Some candidates interpreted the question literally and then wrote at length about feelings on seeing relatives or parents when they had been separated for a period of time, with a lack of development beyond this.

At the middle range, candidates tended to list events chronologically without building a narrative arc. While the content was generally relevant, the writing often lacked a sense of climax or character development. A common issue in these responses was repetition of sentence structures or ideas.

The most successful responses used detail and reflection to create atmosphere, with stronger candidates showing control over sentence variety, punctuation, and tone. Language was often carefully chosen, and there was a clear sense of audience and purpose.

One examiner noted: 'The ones that discussed family members who had passed away were quite beautifully written and those were the one that made me weep.' Another noted ' There were some beautiful responses at the top end, focusing on the resolution of family conflicts.'

Indicate which question you are answering by marking a cross in the box ☒. If you change your mind, put a line through the box ☒ and then indicate your new question with a cross ☒.

Chosen question number: **Question 2** ☒ **Question 3** ☒ **Question 4** ☒

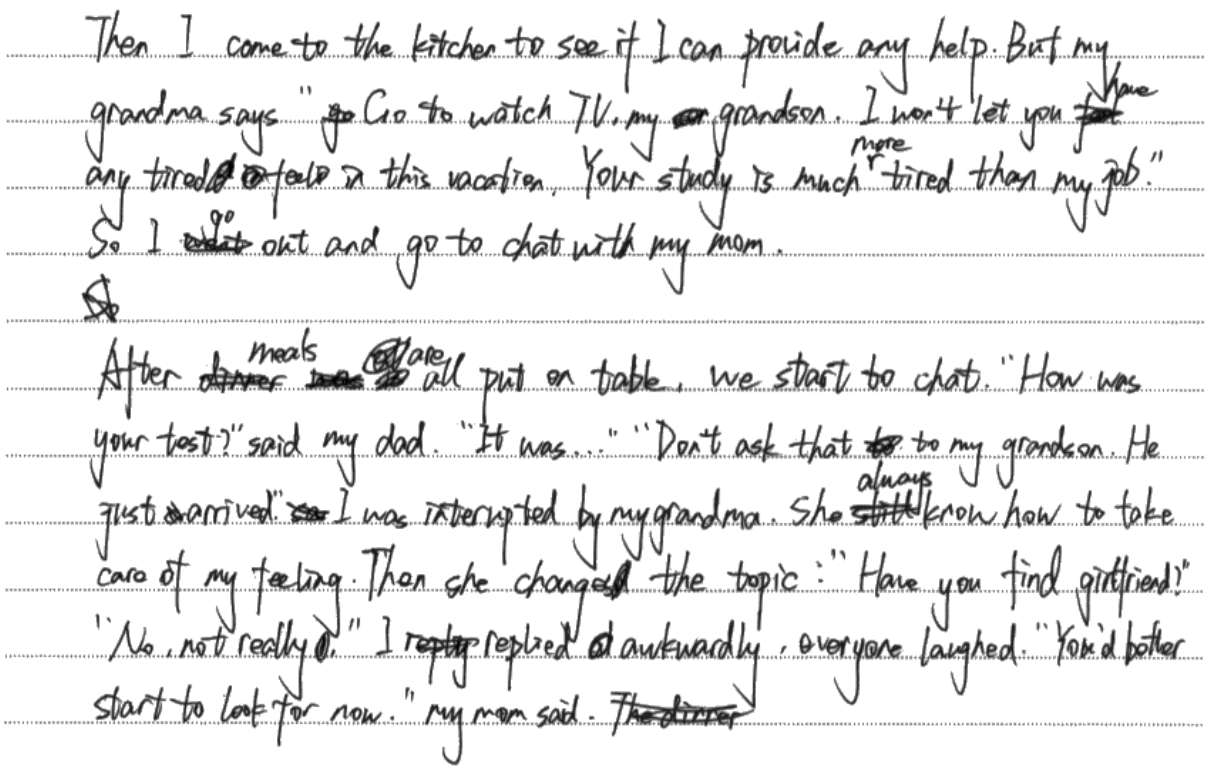
I haven't back to see my grandma for a whole year. No one can understand how much I miss ~~my~~ her and the food she made. Therefore, I decided back to my hometown and visit her in this summer vacation!

"Charger, ~~s~~phone, Identity card. That's all! It's time to go now!"

Just step out ~~from~~ the airport, I have already shocked by the cool wind ~~and cool~~ I ~~saw~~ noticed my mom's car and I ~~walk~~ start to pass the road. "Still cool right?" said my mom, after I get ~~into~~ in the car. "Yeah, ~~that's~~ it's just one of what I was missing" I replied. The car starts and with chatting, we arrive my grandma's home very soon.

"Let me see my grandson. Long time no see!" said my grandma with a hug comes to me. "You can't imagine how much I miss you, grandma" I said. "Let me ~~think~~ guess what you prepared for dinner." I said, with a deep breath, "It must be dumplings!" "You're right my boy. ~~I know~~ I'm sure you missed it also, right?" "Yes of course!"

After a brief greeting, I back to my room and press the charger in. Then ~~I come to the kitchen to see if I can provide any help~~


Then I come to the kitchen to see if I can provide any help. But my grandma says "go Go to watch TV, my ~~or~~ grandson. I won't let you ~~for~~ have any tired ~~of~~ help in this vacation. Your study is much more tired than my job." So I ~~exit~~ go out and go to chat with my mom.

After ~~dinner~~ meals ~~are~~ were all put on table, we start to chat. "How was your test?" said my dad. "It was..." "Don't ask that ~~to~~ to my grandson. He just ~~a~~ arrived" ~~so~~ I was interrupted by my grandma. She ~~still~~ always know how to take care of my feeling. Then she changed the topic: "Have you find girlfriend?" "No, not really." I ~~replay~~ replied awkwardly, everyone laughed. "You'd better start to look for now." my mom said. ~~The dinner~~

ResultsPlus Examiner Comments

AO4 (8 marks): This response achieves everything for AO4 in Level 2. It does communicate in a broadly appropriate way the idea of going on a trip to visit grandma and this idea is actually communicated quite clearly (Level 3). It is a brief response, but brevity is not always an indicator of quality. There is some grasp of purpose, and there is some grasp of the expectations of the reader in terms of this sense of visiting someone. The form, tone and register is fairly straightforward, although there is a real attempt to try and craft some of the language. The straightforward tone comes sometimes from some lapses in the syntax. The ideas are clear, and therefore a mark just into Level 3 can be awarded.

AO5 (6 marks): For AO5 this is a good example of 'best-fit' being given. For the first bullet point we can see ideas are expressed and ordered (Level 2) and they are connected (Level 3). They are not very developed. Level 2 is met for that bullet point and part of Level 3. Looking the second bullet in the mark scheme the response has some varied vocabulary and there is some accurate spelling for example, 'therefore', 'decided', 'vacation', 'dumplings', 'awkwardly'. The candidate attempts to use varied punctuation but there are some lapses in control. They try to adapt sentence structures as appropriate. The 'best-fit' here is the middle of Level 3, as the third bullet point is met in Level 2 due to some lapses in control.

Indicate which question you are answering by marking a cross in the box ☒. If you change your mind, put a line through the box ☒ and then indicate your new question with a cross ☒.

Chosen question number: **Question 2** ☒ **Question 3** ☐ **Question 4** ☐

It was 3:07 A.M. ~~[illegible] pm~~ I remembered exactly - the time ~~I arrived at Dulles New York~~ I landed in New York.

I been sitting the plane for sixteen hours. The air is thin and my ~~body~~ back is ~~tired~~ bored from sixteen-hours of sitting straight and perpendicular to my thibs. My eyes were swollened from pour sleep, and the tiny, red capillaries in my eyes are magnified like they all want to have a chance to be seen by the audience as my eye bulbs were the stage. ~~The sense of discomfort fullfilled my body The sense of dis~~ The sense of discomfort ~~from~~ of prolonged flight and jet leg fullfilled me.

But I don't regret it.

It was finally the time I got to see my friends after 5 whole years of missing and longing ~~to~~ for reunion.

~~The moment I stepped out of the crowded plane and~~ ~~leaved the mess seat~~ squished economy class and stepping ~~on the the JFK~~ airport, ~~every second second of suffering was worthy it~~

Unfortunately, the duration of suffering was prolonged, ~~the plane crash~~ another plane crashed into another. My plane had no other options, but waiting. And there was my signals on the ~~p~~aeroplane. I could not contact my friends, who ~~are~~ were waiting at the arrival exist.

6:57 A.M. That was time ~~or~~ when the aeroplane I ~~was~~ was on can park.

——— After 3 hours and 50 minutes.

The sense of discomfort and sore of muscles exaggerated But, I had to wait until the economy class ~~get~~ could get dismissed. Every second of waiting accumulated to the "torture". It was just 4 minutes, but it felt suprisingly long. I could not explain ~~the urgent~~ how urgent I was to get off the plane. My ~~heart~~ heart rate and the pulse increased. However, my limbs are stiffed and numbed from the extensive long flight. ~~or~~ At the moment when the flight attendance dismissed the economy class, I ~~tragg~~ dragged my exhausted legs to move forward with my subconscious as my brain was filled with the joy that I could meet my friend after 5 whole years. And the crowds pushed forward like ~~the~~ an aggressive flow of water at the mouth of the river, eager to flow into the ocean.

The moment I stepped out of the crowded plane, stepping onto the J.F.K. Airport, the fresh air engulfed me. I breathed rapidly and ~~uncontrollable~~ uncontrolled sniffing the foreign scent of air. ~~The time~~

The time I turned off the airplane mode and recieved signals, the notification of my friends bomberded my phone. It recharged my body, and I could not think more, but rushed towards the ~~exit~~ exist.

When I got out of ~~or~~ the exist, I saw

three farmilar faces in the unformiliar place. I could see the subtle tireness from their eyes from their faces were full of ~~je~~ excitement and joy.

I cun't wait, ~~dcc~~ Then, I ran towards them, forgetly my suitcases. They ~~ca~~ cuddled me with warmth and cozyness ~~.~~.

ResultsPlus
Examiner Comments

AO4 (9 marks): This is an example of a more secure Level 3 response. For AO4, there is a definite clear sense of wanting to see friends, and the idea of the discomfort on a delayed flight. There is a clear sense of purpose and audience, but the tone is occasionally impacted upon by the quality of AO5, and it can sometimes sound a little bit straightforward. For that reason, it achieves a mark of 9 in AO4.

AO5 (7 marks): Again 'best-fit' is needed here. The response does connect ideas that are appropriate and it develops those ideas – the sense of the feelings, the impact on the narrator. There are structural and grammatical features, but we also just need to consider some lapses in control of the sentences. There is varied vocabulary and the vocabulary is bordering on Level 4 as it is quite wide and selective: 'perpendicular', 'magnified', 'prolonged', 'duration, 'notification', 'engulfed'. There are some spelling errors. The use of punctuation is not particularly varied or accurate overall, and there are some lapses in control of sentences. We need to balance that with the quality of vocabulary, so even though that third bullet point does not really meet Level 3, the mark can be pushed to the top of Level 3 given the quality of vocabulary.

Indicate which question you are answering by marking a cross in the box ☒. If you change your mind, put a line through the box ☒ and then indicate your new question with a cross ☒.

Chosen question number: **Question 2** ☑ **Question 3** ☒ **Question 4** ☒

Last year's autumn, around November, I went ~~bac~~ to a suburban village to visit my grandma. It's my first time ~~stepping~~ going to that village.

It was a cloudy day, a typical autumn afternoon. Leaves have already turned yellow and fell from tree, laying on the ground and waiting to be decayed. Trees seemed dull; the low humidity ~~mater~~ made the trees dry and became flaccid, as if an elderly. Wind was blowing gently, but the freeze it brought made me shiver. The cloud shaded the field, covering it up with a greyish tune.

I had a nice and warm dinner with my ~~gra~~ grandma. She talked a lot about her memories with this old ~~has~~ house — the freezing cold spring, the farm that was already abandoned, and the hill at the back of this house. I was curious about the hill. Will it be a nice spot to observe the night sky? I wondered.

My grandma suggested me to wander around and ~~take~~ a look at their natural beauty.

~~[redacted]~~ I went out for this "adventure".
Turn left, go straight, turn left again, and ~~walking~~ walk along the stream. I followed the direction given by my grandma. Climbing up the slope, along a rock stair. The light was dim, perhaps I'm away from the house.
It was silent, Complete silent. The soft sound of watering running, mixed with the unknown insect's ~~insect's~~ buzzing, echoing with the touch of wind on leaves left on the trees. But no sound of people, or cars, as if away from civilisation. I opened my torch as I was stripped by rocks.

The second I saw the surrounding, I froze. My feet were uncontrollably shaking, with my hand ~~Suddening~~ suddenly gripped the torch tighter. Breath held, and the ~~the~~ stream is not flowing anymore, Buzzing disappeared at once. The only sound ~~a~~ heard is the shriek of branches ~~br~~ when brushed by the wind.
I was standing in a graveyard.

I was never a brave kid, and the scene freaked me out. Dried flowers laying here and there, spilling out the smell of decay. Burned papers and objects spreaded the scent of flame, of over-cooked food into the air. Naked trees with wicked branches ~~sta~~ stood tilted. deadly.

I ran. Turn left ... no! Turn right? Go straight! Down the stream ... where's the stream! I couldn't hear the water, the splashes, the soothing flow. All I could hear is my messy breaths, and the fast-pounding heartbeat. I cried, "Anyone here?" No one answered but my own echo.

I ran.

Then, not knowing how long I ran, without directions, I saw light. Warm light from the house. I was ^home again. finally

ResultsPlus
Examiner Comments

AO4 (12 marks): This is an example of a response that achieves all of the bullet points in Level 4 but does not move into Level 5. The response communicates successfully. It is crafted in the sense of description and that creates quite a successful tone in the piece. There are some quite successful features such as rule of 3, some questions, some varied sentence structures and some sounds that are repeated. There is a clear sense of purpose and audience but the response is not always effective in the sense of its security in realising the purpose and audience. It just achieves into Level 4.

AO5 (8 marks): For AO5 the information and ideas are connected and developed, and we have some attempt to manage some ideas as well, for example the idea of building up the tension and then the run home. Verb tenses are an issue which do impact on the quality of AO5, but there is some quite varied vocabulary. There is an attempt to vary the punctuation, question marks, some ellipsis used, but there are some lapses in the creation of verb tenses. For that reason, a mark just into Level 4 is achieved which reflects the management of some of the ideas.

Question 3

Write a story with the title 'The Candlelit Dinner'.

This question was not quite as popular as Question 2. This title inspired a variety of interpretations, ranging from romantic dinners to mystery or suspense stories. Examiners noted that 'these responses were varied'.

Less successful responses lacked narrative shape, often introducing too many underdeveloped characters or ending abruptly. Some candidates struggled to sustain an appropriate tone, or relied too heavily on cliché. Where punctuation and spelling were weak, the overall impact of the piece was affected. Centres might encourage candidates to build writing stamina and experiment with structure, while also reinforcing core writing conventions.

Most candidates chose this option to write about a romantic evening, and many were proposed to at the end, with a lack of development in the narrative. There were a few who took the idea and turned it into a disastrous fire, or an accidental burning of tablecloths and curtains. Despite the somewhat predictable nature of these, candidates utilised the concept to showcase their vocabulary around love and feelings. Some candidates further developed this to create well-rounded characters and (mostly) romantic plots.

The most successful responses used the dinner setting as a backdrop to explore deeper themes such as betrayal, grief, or reconciliation. These narratives were often well-paced and used a range of literary techniques to engage the reader effectively. Candidates who structured their work purposefully, using flashbacks or circular structures, often produced more sophisticated pieces. These responses varied their sentence lengths for effect, used descriptive detail sparingly but effectively and crafted convincing characters.

A summary from one examiner was:

'Some interpreted the candlelit dinner as romantic while others were very creative and crafted spy scenarios or sinister dating apps gone wrong; these tended to fit into the higher levels as they were able to manage information and ideas more skilfully.'

Indicate which question you are answering by marking a cross in the box ☒. If you change your mind, put a line through the box ☒ and then indicate your new question with a cross ☒.

Chosen question number: **Question 2** ☐ **Question 3** ☒ **Question 4** ☐

The Candlelit Dinner

Have you ever had a crush on someone and not know why? Because I have. There is this one girl I would say I'm close to. Her name is Rachel Green. I had known her since I was 8 so that's basically half my life so far. We've been through everything together. She would always be near me and would sit with me through all the boring lectures and would tell me about everything. I always appreciated her prescence and time and I would listen to every story because my studies weren't too serious back then. I loved how expressive and enthusiastic she was whenever she talked to me. Then came the pandemic of COVID-19. At first, I thought it would be a good break from school and all the sacrifices of my sleep schedule. I have a habit of sleeping at 4 AM because of my obsession for football. In Thailand, it's 2 AM when the European football matches begin. My favourite team is FC Barcelona and their matches take place at 9 PM, Spanish time, so I may have the typical Spanish sleep schedule. After a few days, I realised I missed Rachel. I called her phone and she picked up saying 'Hi, I missed you so much'. It felt like we instantly connected like we talked yesterday, but in reality, it had been one and a half month. After that day, we started calling each other everyday. We talked about

everything. I knew every little detail about her and she knew everything I remember about myself. Then school reopened and I saw her again. She felt familiar but different. She wouldn't sit with me during class or talk to me much at school. I had other friends but she felt special. I couldn't lose her. I couldn't replace her. She was perfect in every way. I thought of a risky way to get her attention. One day, I asked her to meet me at the park. When we were there I couldn't stop staring at her because of how cute she was looking. While walking, I asked her the question, 'Would you be mine and call me yours? Will you be my girlfriend?' She happily agreed and we had lots of fun dating for 14 months. One day, she asked me 'What if we had a candlelit dinner like the movies?' I knew it was something she desired so I said 'I'll do it!' We planned a day and decided to do it. I ran into a problem. I couldn't decide what to wear. A pair of pants and a shirt would be too plain, a tux would be too formal. As I was running out of time, I wore khaki pants, a cream shirt and a brown sleeveless sweater. I ~~went~~ reached the restaurant first and took a seat. Rachel entered and everyone was mesmerised by how fabulous she looked. We ate and danced at the club afterwards. While dropping her home, she noticed noone was home so she asked me to come in. We put on music and danced slowly to the ~~music~~ tune. We held each other and looked deeply in ~~our~~ each other's eyes. That was the first time we kissed. Her parents came home soon after so I had to leave. A few days later, she told me she was going to boarding school since her parents want her to have a bright future.

I felt heartbroken she had to leave. She said she would call everyday, but the daily changed to weekly, monthly, alternate monthly to the point where she stopped. I lost contact with her and never saw her again.

ResultsPlus
Examiner Comments

AO4 (10 marks): This response meets Level 3 in the main. The communication is clear and there is a clear sense of purpose and understanding of the audience. Occasionally, the tone is slightly straightforward, so it does not quite meet the top of Level 3. A mark of 10 is awarded.

AO5 (7 marks): A 'best-fit' approach is needed for this Assessment Objective. For AO5, it does meet the top of Level 3 with a mark of 7. The ideas are connected and developed - the ideas of this relationship, how it developed, how it started, how it moved through the pandemic and what happened afterwards. Structural and grammatical features make the meaning clear. Paragraphs are not obvious, although there are some suggestions as to where they could be. There is varied vocabulary, for example 'appreciated', 'presence', 'excessive', 'enthusiastic', 'mesmerised, 'heartbroken'. The response does have a touch of quite wide, selective vocabulary. Spelling is accurate and there is some evidence of accurate and varied punctuation, for example question marks, speech and exclamation marks. Although paragraphing is not really obviously making the meaning clear, given the fact that we have some quite wide selective vocabulary (which is a Level 4 marker), we can award a mark at the top of Level 3.

Indicate which question you are answering by marking a cross in the box ☒. If you change your mind, put a line through the box ☒ and then indicate your new question with a cross ☒.

Chosen question number: **Question 2** ☒ **Question 3** ☒ **Question 4** ☐

The Candlelit Dinner

I've never been good at cooking food. Everytime I tried to cook something it either ended up completely charred or way too raw to eat safely. Even foods that could be served cold would get tortured by the lack of my food-making skills. I'd add too much of one ingredient, too little of another and suddenly I've added bananas to my apple pie. My point is that I've never been good at cooking... or baking... or any other form of food-making.

This is why I have never said no to the opportunity of going out to eat, ever. By now I'm on a first name basis with everyone who has a job involving selling finished

meals, whether they are servers, chefs, managers, I know them all by now. The problem is just that I'm still a college student. I have a part-time job, but eating at restaurants every day is a very expensive life style, especially considering that college isn't exactly very cheap either.

For months I would skip breakfast, eat the lunch served in the cafeteria (no matter how gross it was), and then I'd go to a restaurant nearby, or order fast food for dinner. I knew that that wasn't very healthy, but it's how I lived my first two years at college, and look at me; I survived. Maybe I would even live longer if I kept that life style...

In my third year, however, everything changed. Well, kind of. [redacted] It started with me having the same eating habits as the previous two years. That is until one random day in November. [redacted] 13th of November to be exact. [redacted] I remember that date very well, after

all, you don't forget the days where such crucial events happen.

The day started normally. I was walking out of [redacted] English class when a boy walked up to me. I had seen him around, but never really talked to him a lot. To be honest he seemed kind of [redacted] shady. The three people that got close to him mysteriously disappeared one by one. The teachers say that it was because they moved or changed schools, but the students have different theories.

Anyway, I'm getting off topic, sorry. When the boy walked up to me he seemed slightly nervous. A [redacted] bit of pink covered his cheeks as he approached me. [redacted] He ended up asking if I wanted to eat dinner with him. Honestly, I wasn't interested, but he offered free

food so I said yes.

7 PM that Friday I walked over to his house. He lead me to the table where the only source of light was a scented candle. The candle made the whole room smell like cinamon. At first I thought he chose cinamon because it was almost Christmas, but I was wrong.

The meal was ok, chicken with some vegetables, but it tasted... weird. I later left his house, but I never made it home. A few meters away from his house I felt a sharp pain in my stomach before I collapsed. That's the last I remember.



AO4 (13 marks): This response meets all of Level 3 for AO4 and we therefore look to Level 4. It starts out with some very successful crafting of the person's success with cooking and has some nice touches of humour and the idea of why they go out to eat and why they tend to go out to eat is very clear. By the time the response gets to the third page, there is some lapse in the success of the piece, for example 'Anyway, I'm getting off topic, sorry.' It just starts to get a little bit further away from the success that it started out with. There's a little bit of just stating of what's happening, for example this particular boy who is 'kind of shady', is not quite as successful as the earlier description. However, all of Level 3 is met and there is some success at crafting the particular persona of the narrator, and for that reason a mark of 13 at the lower end of Level 4 is achieved.

AO5 (8 marks): For AO5 the response fully meets Level 3 and there is some management of ideas, moving the mark just into Level 4. Paragraphing and sentence structure are clear. The vocabulary and punctuation are varied and spelling and punctuation overall are accurate. There is evidence of the candidate adapting sentence structures for effect.

Indicate which question you are answering by marking a cross in the box ☒. If you change your mind, put a line through the box ☒ and then indicate your new question with a cross ☒.

Chosen question number: **Question 2** ☐ **Question 3** ☒ **Question 4** ☐

The Candlelit Dinner

It was a chilly night. The winds were hollering, and the sky was a foggy old painting, filled with toxic gas and smoke. This was not your ordinary Christmas eve. This was ~~Novem~~ December 24th in 1915, in a small French suburb. WWI was raging on, gunshots firing, bombs exploding, resources scarce, and people hopeless. The streets were filled with litter and bullet shells, the buildings bare and broken. Festive cues could not be heard, colorful nights and lush Christmas trees could not be seen, christmas carols and songs could not be heard — this was a special Christmas eve indeed.

In one of these homes, ~~there~~ Ava slouched against the cold fireplace wall. She thought to herself, this past year has been so miserable. She couldn't go to school or any clubs to meet up with her friends, she couldn't go outside to buy delicious treats or play with the snow, she couldn't buy new books or toys. She ~~didn't~~ hated ~~know that was going on~~ the war, ~~why~~ she hated the loud noises and screams that could be heard outside each night, ~~okay~~ she hated that they had no money to buy things, ~~why~~ and that her parents looked sad, grim and frightened everyday.

"Honey, it's dinner time!" a familiar voice warmly called out. It was her father. He tried to muster up a smile, his face was sweaty and eyes were wet.

"Okay." Ava replied. Overtime, she didn't really know what to feel anymore. She had become numb to it all.

The electricity went off, so the bright lights were replaced by four small candles. One on each corner of the small wooden rectangular table. Tonight, a red and white tablecloth had been placed, although they couldn't afford a new one, so it had several tears and patches. Dinner was a basket of bread and some tomato soup, which Ava thought was considerably better than the stale potatoes and cabbage she had all year.

The family of three each sat on their respective stalls, and huddled together. There was a long silence.

"So... today is Christmas Eve." Ava's Mother finally said quietly, as the three glanced down on the table.

"It is... it has been a rough year for our family, but we made it. We are quite fortunate, so let us enjoy our time together, no matter how rough things are.", her father chimed in.

Ava said numbly: "Let's just eat."

After the somewhat fulfilling dinner, the family sat together next to the withering Christmas tree from the previous year.

"Ava darling, we have a present for you."

She looked at the present. It was wrapped carefully with newspaper, and had a pretty red bow on top. This year, she didn't expect anything, as she knew times were tough and their financial situation was dire, so she was considerably surprised. She unwrapped the present delicately.

It was a handmade binder, full of precious memories and photos from her childhood. It was decorated with many beautiful dry flowers emitting a pleasant aroma, and everything was put

together extremely well and with precision.

Staring at the binder, Ava couldn't help but realize that her eye sockets began to get filled with tears. This was the first time in a long time that she had felt something. Something real. The happiness of skiing the first time with her parents, the fulfillment of winning a creative writing competition, the exhiliaration of baking cookies with her mom and dad.

Uncontrollably, she burst into tears, and tightly embraced her parents. She realised that life wasn't about what you didn't have, but appreciating what you had in the moment. She had spent too much time focusing on the difficulties brought by the war that she forgot what mattered most — family and companionship. Even though times were tough, as long as they were together, they could get through it.

"I.. I love you guys" she exclaimed holding back tears, still struggling to speak, "we can do this".

The three smiled and recounted happy memories that night. This was indeed a special Christmas eve. Despite there not being fancy decorations and a brightly lit room, only having four small candles and a withering tree — they had the most important thing: each other.



AO4 (16 marks): This is an example of a response that 'grows' into its mark. Initially, it appears to be meeting all of Level 4. It communicates successfully the feelings of the child during the war. It has secure realisation of purpose and the audience, with effective use of form, tone and register. The voice of the child in the story comes through very clearly. There is some achievement of Level 5, however. The response is successful and because it is sharply focused on purpose and audience, it just moves into Level 5. The ideas are quite perceptively presented.

AO5 (11 marks): Level 5 is just met for AO5. There is management of information and ideas, with structural and grammatical features used cohesively and deliberately across the text. There is wide, selective vocabulary used and spelling is accurate. There is a range of punctuation used for clarity, managing sentence structures for deliberate effect. The mark just moves into Level 5 given the accuracy and the way the ideas are managed in quite a complex manner.

Question 4

Look at the images provided. Write a story that ends 'It moved into the shadows'.

This question was the most popular this summer, perhaps as it gave such a broad direction for candidates to take.One examiner noted "This prompt encouraged a range of imaginative responses, with some choosing supernatural or suspense genres while others explored metaphorical interpretations of 'the shadows'." Whilst most candidates used elements of horror/gothic genre, with some success, the most interesting were those who took different angles on the prompt. A couple wrote about animals and nature, and these stories were crafted well.

The least successful responses often lost narrative control or failed to build towards the conclusion logically. A few stories did not link to the ending line at all or used it without purpose, which limited their effectiveness. These responses often struggled with basic sentence demarcation and consistency of tense. Some overused short sentences in an attempt to create tension, but this sometimes led to stilted writing.

The most effective responses built towards the final line with careful control of pace and mood. Some chose to withhold information from the reader until the end, creating a twist or moment of ambiguity that made the final sentence particularly effective. Candidates who remained focused on a single idea or character and used sensory detail to develop tension tended to create successful responses.

Examiner comments include:

- 'These responses were often creepy and scary ending with 'it moved into the shadows' but some that stood out used the prompt very creatively. They crafted stories that had elements of mystery and in some cases love and sadness and the whole range of emotions.'
- 'This was the most popular choice and led to a number of macabre and disturbing responses with severed heads, creatures of the night and death!'
- '...on the whole there were well-developed plots, some with excellent twists, and candidates seemed to enjoy writing these stories.'
- 'Planning is particularly important with an 'ending line' prompt to ensure the ending feels like a natural conclusion rather than abrupt.'

Indicate which question you are answering by marking a cross in the box ☒. If you change your mind, put a line through the box ☒ and then indicate your new question with a cross ☒.

Chosen question number: **Question 2** ☒ **Question 3** ☒ **Question 4** ☒

No one ~~knows~~ knew where he is from. no one ~~knows~~ knew where he will been.

He walked along the country with a grey hat, a huge coat and a long stick. 'Tala, Tala, Tala' is the sound that he made when he walks.

He was ~~the~~ such kind ~~man~~ that no one ever seen. He picked up rubbish on the streets, he helped elders walk accorss, he donated poors from the churoh. No one knew his name, everyone just called him 'Uncle good'.

The time passed day by day. ~~and~~ When uncle good just passed the street another time, he saw a ~~a~~ homeless ~~person~~ ~~lying~~ who is standing by the trash bin, discovering something for food. Uncle good immediately stopped him and asked ~~for~~ him for reason, the person replied 'Cause I don't have money for food.' Uncle good ~~he~~ heard it, he let the person go with him to a resturant, ~~afford~~ afforded a meal for him and give him a hundred pounds ~~to~~ for ~~a~~ food before he find a work. The person asked him why he is so kind ~~to~~ for him. Uncle good didn't answer.

After a few days, uncle good met ~~the~~that guy again. He's lying by the bin at night, looking exhasted.

Uncle good: 'Why are you here then?'

He replied 'I didn't have nice and neat clothes, my boss asked my ~~to~~ to get ~~rid~~ out of his office, "the money used up quickly for food and rent.'

Uncle good didn't say anything more, ~~and~~ he just stay silence and give him a thousand pounds, the person still about to say something, ~~w~~ but uncle good quickly walked away with the 'Tala' sound of the stick

A month later, uncle good met the person the third time, this time he was sitting down the bridge, dirt is full on his clothes and body.

The third time uncle good asked the man for the reason of why are he so poor again, he replied, ~~he~~ 'My business failed and I ~~can't~~ don't even have a cent now. Do you have something more for me?'

Uncle good didn't replied, he just ~~give~~ gave the rest ~~of~~ money he had to the person and his ~~valued~~ ~~pie~~ pircefu1 watch to him, then walked away, With the sound of the stick, it moved into the shadows.

ResultsPlus
Examiner Comments

AO4 (7 marks): This response meets all of Level 2. It communicates in a broadly appropriate way the idea of 'Uncle Good' and the idea of linking back to the movement into the shadows is broadly appropriate. There is some grasp of purpose, not fully clear and some sense of the expectations of the reader. The straightforward use of form, tone and register and some lapses in clarity prevent it from moving into Level 3.

AO5 (4 marks): The ideas are expressed and ordered. There is an order to what Uncle Good is doing and an order in his discussions with this particular person he meets. There is some correctly spelled vocabulary, 'donated', 'homeless', 'discovering', 'immediately' and there is some attempt to use punctuation with control, for example, the speech marks used. There are some missing full stops. There is no real attempt to create too much of a range of sentence structures. There are some repeated sentence structures (for example in the opening lines) which seem to be deliberate and for that reason we can go to the top of Level 2 with a mark of 4.

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Chosen question number: **Question 2** ☒ **Question 3** ☒ **Question 4** ☒

~~It~~ Dreams are a part of everyone's life. Sometimes exciting, sometimes dull. Nightmares are also a part of everyone's life, just maybe not like the ones I experience.

One quiet evening, I sat beside ~~my~~ the window right next to ~~by~~ my bed, staring at the dull atmosphere, the dull faces walking by. ~~The~~ ~~it~~ This ~~was~~ didn't seem like a normal day, the birds weren't chirping, the sunset wasn't relaxing. It seemed like the sun was tired too, just like me.

I took an off from work that day, I ~~did not~~ just really did not feel like spending hours ~~Looking~~ staring at a screen, in the same position all day. Work is starting to feel ~~like~~ like a burden. It's not exciting anymore, it's ~~not~~ not fun anymore. Or maybe it's just the fact that I haven't been feeling like myself lately, and I can't figure out why, and it's driving me nuts.

Everyday feels the same, grey, dull, and pretty exhausting. I haven't been able to make time for myself at all nowadays,

and I think it shows on my face. My skin's been breaking out, my eyes feel heavy, my body aches and yearns for rest. Every morning I wake up and feel like I hadn't slept all night, and I can't figure out why. Is it the excessive amount of energy drinks ~~tha~~ I've been drinking recently? Maybe. But that would mean I'm not getting any sleep at all. These aren't sleepless nights, and if it isn't ~~something~~ caused by something external, then it must be something during ~~t~~ my sleep.

I feel this strange sense of anxiety ~~all the time, and I have very faint~~ as soon as I wake up. ~~It~~ Tiredness overcomes me even though I had just woken up from what felt like a literal coma. ~~Is something's bothering me, or is am I just going insane? Do I need to see a psychiatrist? I don't know.~~

~~All I~~

Something's bothering me, or am ~~I~~ I just going insane? I don't know.

All I know is that it comes to me while I sleep, and ~~takes all my energy~~ snatches all my energy away. I can't let this

keep happening. ~~I spent~~
I had spent all day wondering what it could be; ~~and was~~ Is it a ghost? I don't believe in ghosts. Is it a serial killer? ~~who's~~ wouldn't I be dead by now? Is it some ~~entity that has~~ mysterious entity that has the powers to ~~mess~~ mess with my brain? Most likely.
I had ~~come~~ finally come to the conclusion that if I were to ~~figure out~~ be able to figure out anything, it would most definitely be at night. ~~I've already~~ I'm already confident with the fact that it happens while I sleep, so I guess I'll just have to wait.
Update, it is 2:39 AM and I'm still awake. Why, you may ask. Well, that's a ~~good~~ question, because I'm not sure either. Maybe it's the anxiety, the fear of the unknown, the fear of what's about to come, ~~and~~ knowing very well that I'm not ready for it at all.
I searched my drawers, frantically shoving my hand, moving it around as ~~I feel~~ my hand comes across an abnormal amount of medicines bottles. Yes, I struggle

with a lot of things, and sleep is one of them. I'm pretty sure it's insomnia, but I haven't really been diagnosed yet. Anyways, I finally found my sleeping pills and shoved it down ~~by~~ my throat as I ~~gulped a gl~~ drank a glass of water all in one breath. I could feel my eyes ~~start~~ slowly getting heavier, it's ~~to~~ show time.

I woke up in the middle of a ~~room. A~~ Kitchen. Not just any Kitchen, a restaurant Kitchen. ~~not~~

~~What am I do~~ "Where am I?" I thought. That's when I heard the sound of metal ~~clinging~~ clanking. As if, someone was tapping sharp blades on the ~~kitche~~'s metal stove. I ~~looked around~~ walked ~~around~~ further, ~~at~~ ~~fitted~~ my heart filled with fear, not the normal kind. It was the fear ~~the~~ that drags your heart down, putting a lot of weight on it. I came across this ~~man~~, tall, ~~man fair~~'s man wearing a brown cowboy hat, and a red t-shirt with black stripes. ~~on~~ ~~on~~ As I scanned him up and down, I noticed he was wearing gloves. ~~Not~~ ~~Bu~~

But not just any gloves.

Now I know where the sound of metal tapping came from. It was the blades at ~~the~~ the fingertips of his gloves.
He just stood there, ~~with~~ a blank stare in his eyes. completely neutral. Then came a smirk, as he ran ~~rigid~~ straight towards me and I suddenly woke up.
my heart was pounding, ~~I my breath~~ as I ~~ga~~ desperately gasped for air. My throat was as dry as the Sahara desert, as I turned towards my side table, I noticed a figure standing in the doorway. Exactly like the one I had seen in my dream. ~~It moved into the shadows.~~ Or should ~~I call it might~~ say, night mare. ~~As~~ I was about to get up to look at it ~~from~~ closely. ~~I couldn't believe it, I thought~~ Am I hallucinating?
I threw my blanket ~~aw~~ off of myself but it was too late, it was gone. It had moved into the shadows.

ResultsPlus
Examiner Comments

AO4 (15 marks): For AO4, this response meets Level 4 fully on balance. It does communicate clearly (Level 3) and it does show a clear sense of purpose and audience using appropriate form, tone and register. However, there are some touches of success in what the response is doing. Some lengthy description can detract a little bit from what we feel is most successful and makes it feel less secure in its realisation of purpose and audience, but overall it is effective and successful at presenting the mystery of the symptoms, what the narrator is going through and whatever this presence may be. For that reason, the response does achieve the top of Level 4 with a mark of 15.

AO5 (10 marks): For AO5, the first bullet point meets Level 4. There is an attempt to manage the information and ideas where there is a deliberate attempt to build up tension, and there is a wide selective vocabulary used, for example 'exhausting', 'excessive', 'insomnia', 'diagnosed' and 'hallucinating'. There are no spelling errors, but there are some lapses in grammar and control of punctuation. There is a range of punctuation question marks, for example, and the candidate does try to manage sentence structures for deliberate effect. On that basis, the candidate can be awarded a mark of 10 at the top of Level 4. The accuracy of the spelling, the wide selective vocabulary and the attempt to manipulate sentence structure just pushes it to the top of that level.

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Chosen question number: **Question 2** ☒ **Question 3** ☒ **Question 4** ☒

The wind screamed across the headland, tearing at my coat as I found my way towards Gran's abandoned lighthouse. The Sentinel. Salt spray stung my face. Below, the sea raged against black rocks. Old Man Hemlock's crumpled letter in my pocket demanded I come before the equinox storm. "What you seek is there," it promised, mysteriously.

Shoving the heavy, salt-crusted door open felt like a victory. Inside, the air was thick with dust and silence. The vast base chamber was dim, lit only by grimy portholes revealing the storm's fury. Following Hemlock's instructions, I headed for the cramped cupboard under the spiral staircase, pushing aside mildewed tarps and rusted tools.

There, behind a fishy-smelling crate, was a small iron-bound sea chest. Not the 'watchkeeper's log' I'd imagined. My pulse quickened. Kneeling on cold flagstones, I wrestled the stiff latch open. Inside, nestled on faded blue velvet, lay a smooth, dark lens, humming faintly with warmth. Beneath it was a single sheet of paper covered in Gran's unmistakable handwriting.

"Ken," It began, making my throat tighten. "The Sentinel was more than a warning light. This lens shows trapped memories, stirred by the storm. Look through it at the Needle Rocks at the storm's peak. The truth will change things."

A tremendous crash shook the tower. The storm was reaching its height. Heart hammering, I stumbled back to the main chamber and lifted the warm lens to the largest salt-streaked porthole, aiming it at the Needle Rocks where waves ~~explored~~ exploded like bombs.

The world shifted violently. The churning sea wasn't empty. Flickering, ghostly figures appeared - impressions of terror. A wooden ship, long ago, shattered against the Needles like kindling. I saw frantic lantern lights vanish under waves. I heard faint, swallowed screams echoing beneath the present storm's roar.

Then, clearer: a small lifeboat. Figures struggled. One, unmistakably Gran-younger, her face a mask of fear and fierce determination - hauled a small, limp shape from the surging water. A child. A child with hair so pale it ~~was~~ seemed to glow against the dark sea.

A jolt of pure recognition hit me like lightning. Me. That pale hair was mine. I wasn't born on the island. I was a

foundling. Rescued. ~~Had~~ Hidden. Gran's fierce protectiveness, the islander's occasional awkward silences about my arrival - it all slammed into place with brutal clarity.

The vision vanished. The lens cooled instantly in my hand. Outside, the storm still raged, but inside the tower, a different kind of tempest roared: shock, confusion, but beneath it, a dawning understanding. ~~Gran~~ Gran hadn't just saved me; she'd given me a home, an anchor. The wild sea beyond the glass had tried to claim me; this stone tower had kept me safe and the secret behind. I wasn't just Ken anymore. I was Ken who knew. Placing the lens back in its velvet bed, I closed the chest. ~~The~~ The ~~big~~ truth was a heavy weight, but also a kind of light. Walking back into the shrieking wind, the path down felt different. I finally knew where I belonged, leaving my innocent behind, it moved into the shadows.

ResultsPlus
Examiner Comments

AO4 (18 marks): This is an example of a response awarded full marks. It is a very good example of that achievement, given that it has relative brevity. It is very much sharply focused on purpose and the intended reader. The communication is perceptive, it is very well crafted and the story is very much focused on sophisticated ideas from this particular genre of writing.

AO5 (12 marks): Level 5 is also fully met for AO5. The ideas are complex, for example this idea of belonging, the background to this family and the future. There are a range of structural and grammatical features used across the response and extensive vocabulary. It is used strategically linked to this particular style of writing, and there are very rare spelling errors – it appears just the one right at the end. The sentence structures are used accurately and selectively to achieve particular effects.

Paper Summary

Based on their performance on the paper, candidates are offered the following advice:

- Ensure you have studied the poetry and prose texts in the Anthology fully and use the examination time to remind yourself of the text, not re-read it.
- Even where the text is a short poem, consider what the key points are linked to the question you are being asked.
- Make you are covering the whole poem from beginning to end in order to meet AO1 in the higher levels.
- Read the question carefully and make sure you are answering **this** question, not telling the examiner what you know about the poem you have studied. The selection needs to be relevant to the question you are being asked.
- For AO2 (language and structure), make sure you are offering ideas about ***how*** language and structure are used. Many of you were able to give examples, but sometimes you did not offer a comment about the example was used.
- For AO2, try to cover points on both language and structure, commenting on the different techniques that have been used by the writer and how they link to the overall topic of the question, in this case how the events are presented.
- When you are writing, always think about your reader, what information and ideas you want to develop and how you want the reader to react at different parts of your writing; then choose the best words, phrases or techniques available to you to achieve those effects. Think about 'how do you want your reader to feel?' and 'how will you achieve this?' to encourage more conscious crafting of writing.
- Listen to your teacher's advice and make sure to plan - some responses felt as if they had little purpose or understanding of how they were going to conclude.
- Think carefully about starts and ends. Think about how you will begin to write so that it is engaging for your reader from the very start. As you begin to write, know where you will end. This will help you to write in a manner that is cohesive and coherent for your reader.
- Take care throughout with accuracy: spelling, punctuation and grammar
- In writing, focus on crafting and organisation whatever the nature of the task.
- Be ambitious in your structure, vocabulary and range of ideas and try to be creative and original.
- Always respond to the questions set, not a question you have prepared – this rarely leads to effective responses as the response needs to be appropriate and at least clearly linked to the purpose (i.e. the title).

Grade boundaries

Grade boundaries for this, and all other papers, can be found on the website on this link: https://qualifications.pearson.com/en/support/support-topics/results-certification/grade-boundaries.html

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